Reading the Scale

The number moves for about nine reasons. Only one of them is fat.

What a normal week actually looks like, why Monday can be a fright, and the honest answer when it has not moved at all.

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GARY BROWN | CHARTERED PHYSIOTHERAPIST | COACH
GARY@GARYBROWNHERE.COM

01

What normal looks like

Roughly **half a percent to one percent of your bodyweight a week.** That is the range worth aiming at, and it looks slower on paper than you expect.

IF YOU ARE	A GOOD WEEK IS	OVER FOUR WEEKS
80kg	0.4 to 0.8kg	1.6 to 3.2kg
90kg	0.45 to 0.9kg	1.8 to 3.6kg
100kg	0.5 to 1kg	2 to 4kg
110kg	0.55 to 1.1kg	2.2 to 4.4kg

Faster is not better

If it is coming off much quicker than that for more than a week or two, a fair bit of what is leaving is muscle and water rather than fat. You end up lighter, softer, weaker and hungrier, and it comes back on. That is the thing we are actually trying to avoid, and it is why the number we want is a modest one.

The first fortnight is not a fair sample

Most guys drop more than that in the first week or two. That is mostly water and stored carbohydrate going, not a sudden transformation, and it slows down afterwards. Nothing has gone wrong when it does. You were never losing three kilos of fat in a week.

> THE ROUGH ARITHMETIC
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> A kilo of body fat is somewhere around 7,700 calories. So a deficit of about 500 a day, held across a week, gets you roughly half a kilo. That is the shape of it. It also shows you why one heavy weekend can cancel five good days without you doing anything dramatic.

02

Why it bounces around

Your weight can move a kilo or two in a day without a gram of fat changing hands. Knowing what is behind it takes most of the sting out of a bad reading.

WHAT MOVES IT	WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING
A high carbohydrate day	Every gram of stored carbohydrate holds three to four grams of water with it. A big pasta or bread day can show up as a kilo or more.
A salty meal or a takeaway	Sodium pulls water in. It is gone again within a day or two.
Alcohol	Messes with fluid balance in both directions, and the food that comes with it adds volume.
A poor night's sleep	Raises the hormones that hold onto fluid, and it is one of the more common reasons for a strange Monday.

A hard session	Muscle holds extra fluid while it repairs. Perfectly normal, and it is a sign it worked.
Simply not having been to the jacks	Worth more on the scale.
Weighing at a different time	Which is why it is always first thing, before food or drink.

> ABOUT THE MONDAY WEIGH-IN
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> After a weekend the Monday number is often up, sometimes by a kilo or two. Almost none of that is fat. It is food volume, carbohydrate, salt and fluid, and most of it is gone by Wednesday. Read it as information about the weekend rather than a verdict, and whatever you do, do not go punishing yourself on the back of it.

This is why we look at the trend across weeks rather than any single morning. One reading tells you almost nothing. Six readings tell you everything.

03

If it has not moved

Two or three weeks in, the trend is flat, and you feel like you have been doing everything right. This is the part nobody enjoys hearing, so I will put it plainly and kindly.

> THE HONEST ANSWER
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> If your weight is holding steady over a few weeks, you are eating at roughly the amount your body is using. You are not in a deficit yet. That is not a judgement and it is not a failure, it is just the arithmetic, and it is nearly always where the answer is.

And it is almost never that you are eating too little, which is the explanation the internet will offer you first. If the number is not moving, more food is not the fix.

Where the extra usually hides

- **The weekend.** Two heavy days can quietly undo five good ones. This is the first place I look, every time.
- **What you drink.** Lattes, juice, mixers, the pint you did not count. Liquid calories land on top of the day.
- **Fats and oils.** Oil in the pan, nuts, cheese, dressings, nut butter. None of it feels like much and it is the most calorie dense thing on the plate.
- **Portion drift.** Portions creep up quietly over a few weeks, especially with the things you consider healthy.
- **The bits between meals.** A taste while cooking, the kids' leftovers, a few biscuits with the tea.

None of that is a character flaw. It is the ordinary way a deficit disappears, and every one of us does it. The fix is a week of honest tracking so we can see it, rather than guessing at it.

04

The hormone question

There is a lot online telling guys that their hormones, their stress, their cortisol or their metabolism are the reason the weight will not shift. It is a comfortable explanation and it is mostly the wrong one.

What stress and poor sleep genuinely do

They are real and they matter, but they matter through your behaviour rather than around it. A bad week of sleep raises the hormones that drive hunger and lowers the ones that tell you that you have had enough. The afternoon slump gets fed with the wrong thing, the evening picking starts earlier, and the walk after dinner never happens.

So they change what you eat and how much you move. What they do not do is suspend the arithmetic. Nobody stores fat out of thin air because they had a rough quarter at work.

Why this matters

If you understand that stress works by changing your decisions, then it becomes something you can actually manage, and everything else in the plan is aimed at exactly that.

> WORTH SAYING
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> If you genuinely suspect something medical is going on, thyroid or anything else, go and get bloods done. That is a doctor's job, not a coach's, and I would rather you ruled it out than wondered about it. For the overwhelming majority, it is the calories.

05

What to watch instead

The scale is one measure and it is the least honest one. These four together give you the real picture.

WHAT	HOW OFTEN	WHY IT IS WORTH MORE
Waist at the belly button	Every 4 weeks	Tracks fat loss more honestly than anything else you can measure at home.
Photos, front and side	Every 4 weeks	The mirror changes before the scale does. Same spot, same light, morning.
How the clothes feel	Ongoing	Belt notch, shirts, the jeans you know. You will notice this first.
Your strength numbers	Every session	Going up while the waist comes down means you are losing the right thing.

THE COMBINATION THAT TELLS YOU IT IS WORKING

Waist coming down, strength going up, clothes looser, and the scale moving slowly. That is the best result available and it is often the one that feels the most disappointing on a Monday morning. Hold your nerve with it.

How to weigh yourself

- Same two mornings each week, first thing, before food or drink.
- After the toilet, before the shower, wearing roughly the same thing.
- Put the scales somewhere you cannot walk past. It is a two week habit to build.
- Look at the trend across weeks, never at a single morning.

One reading tells you almost nothing. Six of them tell you everything.

Gary Brown Chartered Physiotherapist | Coach | gary@garybrownhere.com